

Tech titans clash over AI's future: open source vs proprietary systems

Industry leaders are sharply divided over the future of artificial intelligence (AI). Meta and IBM have launched the AI Alliance, championing an 'open science' approach, while giants like Google, Microsoft, and OpenAI stand staunchly behind closed, proprietary systems.

Darío Gil, IBM's senior vice president, asserted the open advocates' stance: "The future of AI is going to be built fundamentally on top of the open scientific exchange of ideas and on open innovation." The AI Alliance, backed by IBM and Meta, includes industry heavyweights like Dell, Sony, AMD, Intel, and several universities.

However, Ilya Sutskever, chief scientist at OpenAI, acknowledged the short-term commercial hurdles against open source and voiced concerns



about the potential risks tied to highly advanced AI systems.

Critics caution against open source AI, citing unique risks. David Evan Harris from UC Berkeley warned that even open source AI models could fuel disinformation campaigns, posing threats to democratic processes.

The clash has spilled into the public domain, with Meta's chief AI scientist, Yann LeCun, accusing rivals of "massive corporate lobbying." LeCun emphasised openness as essential for AI systems housing human knowledge and culture.

In this high-stakes battle, tech giants are vying for influence, shaping the destiny of AI – whether it becomes an open platform for shared knowledge or stays confined within proprietary domains remains to be seen.

LLM360 framework unveiled by Cerebras Systems, Petuum, and MBZUAI

In a groundbreaking collaboration, Cerebras Systems, Petuum, and Mohamed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence (MBZUAI) have unveiled LLM360, a revolutionary open source framework designed to propel the development of large language models (LLMs). This strategic partnership, particularly with MBZUAI's Institute of Foundation Models, promises to reshape the landscape of artificial intelligence by providing developers with unprecedented insights and methodologies.

Developed to simplify, expedite, and reduce costs in the creation of LLMs, LLM360 has introduced two open source models. Amber, a 7 billion parameter English-language model trained on an extensive 1.2 trillion tokens, is joined by CrystalCoder, a similarly powerful model designed for English language and coding tasks, also boasting 7 billion parameters and trained on 1.4 trillion tokens. Both models are released under the Apache 2.0 license, ensuring a wide range of applications and accessibility for developers.

Excitingly, another model named Diamond, with a staggering 65 billion parameters, is set to be released soon. These models are the result of intensive training on the Condor Galaxy 1 supercomputer, a collaborative effort between G42 and Cerebras Systems.

The LLM360 initiative marks a significant leap in artificial intelligence capabilities, as the models are built on Meta's LLaMA architecture. In particular,

Biden administration dives into open source AI debate

In a pivotal move, the Biden administration is taking a hands-on approach to the debate over the impact of open source AI models on society. The White House's recent AI executive order has charged the National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA) with investigating and offering recommendations.

"We've been given a clear homework assignment. We're not trying to prejudice it one way or the other," said NTIA administrator Alan Davidson. While AI models from giants like OpenAI, Google, and Microsoft are closely guarded, some are available under full open source licences.

The open source AI discussion goes beyond ownership, touching on national security, bioterrorism risks, and public accessibility. Davidson appreciated President Biden's approach, stating, "I'm glad no one jumped to one conclusion or the other. That would be easy to do."

While reserving judgment, Davidson stressed the need for balanced policies: "This isn't an either/or [situation]. We need policies that are going to promote both safety and allow for broad access to AI tools."

Potential solutions include risk-based approaches and safeguards preventing easy removal of safety mechanisms from open source models. Davidson stressed on immediate concerns like bias, security, and trust rather than just existential risks.

The NTIA, under the Commerce Department, will initiate its investigation with an online event and a public comment period early this year. Simultaneously, it is working on a report exploring government-led initiatives to encourage auditable and accountable AI systems.